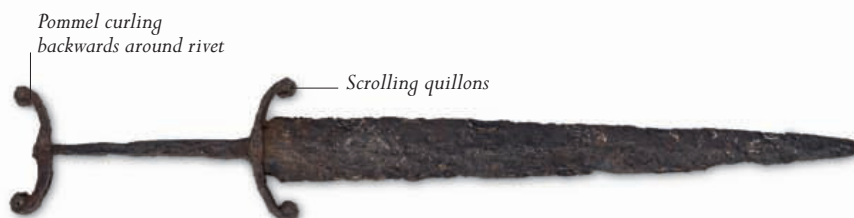


MEDIEVAL ARCHERS

Armies up to the Middle Ages made good use of archers, although the simple bows they used made firepower relatively limited. Crossbows became common for a time in the 12th and 13th centuries, but by the mid-14th century the English, in particular, were deploying a powerful new weapon – the longbow – whose greater range enabled them to nullify the advantage the armoured knights possessed. As with most medieval men-at-arms, the archers used a range of daggers to defend themselves at close quarters, should their volleys be insufficient to drive off attackers.



▲ QUILLON DAGGER

Date 14th century

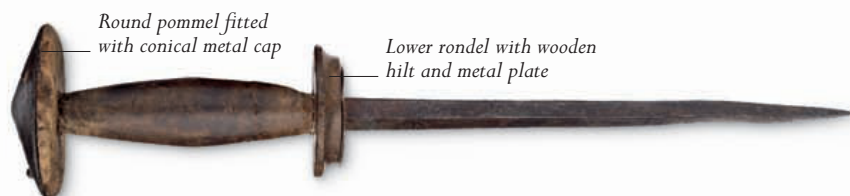
Origin England

Weight 110g (4oz)

Length 30.8cm (12in)

This dagger has prominent quillons that curve down towards its blade. Its atypical pommel exhibits a similar curved effect, mirroring the quillons. Such daggers were especially popular with men of high rank, particularly when wearing civilian dress.

Projecting gutter rising to a peak offered extra protection



▲ RONDEL DAGGER

Date 15th century

Origin England

Weight 230g (8oz)

Length 35cm (13¾in)

The rondel was the main military dagger during the early 15th century, distinguished by the round discs that formed the guard and the pommel. It was also known as the *dague à rouelles*, and was a popular dagger among those of high social status.



▲ BALLOCK DAGGER

Date c.1500

Origin England

Weight 170g (6oz)

Length 34.9cm (13¾in)

Also known as a “kidney dagger”, this weapon was named after the distinctive shape of its guard with two rounded lobes. It was popular in England and the Low Countries, and was most commonly worn with civilian dress rather than armour.

► BUCKLER

Date c.1500

Origin Europe

Diameter 15–45cm (6–18in)

The buckler, a small round shield, formed part of an archer's equipment for hand-to-hand combat. It was capable of deflecting light blows from maces or swords, while the raised central boss – as seen on this modern replica – could itself be used as a weapon to strike against an opponent.



▲ PAVISE

Date Mid-15th century

Origin Bohemia

Weight 9.7kg (21¼lb)

Length 1.13m (3¾ft)

Pavises (named after the Italian city of Pavia) were long convex wooden shields often used to protect archers, and crossbowmen in particular, as their slow rate of fire made them particularly vulnerable. This one formed part of a set of 40 ordered by the Swiss city of Zwickau, in 1441.